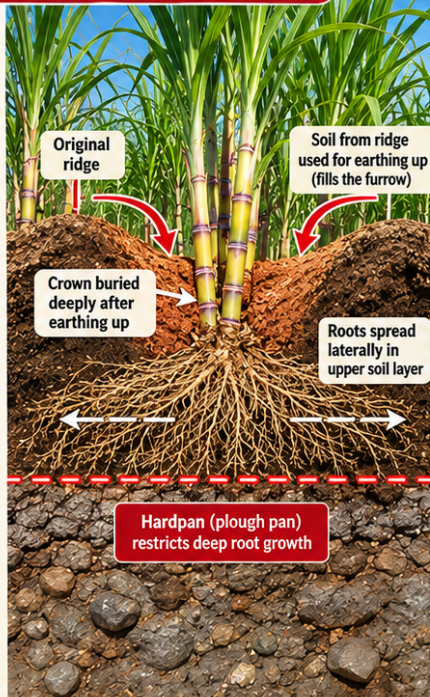
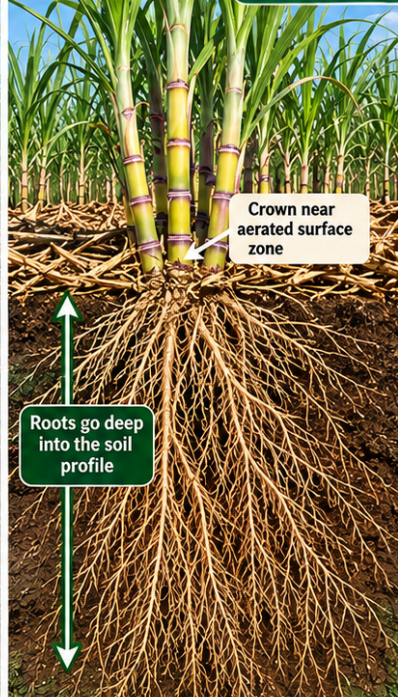


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Why PQNK Sugarcane Does Not Need Earthing Up

Remove the Cause, and the Corrective Operation Becomes Unnecessary

Asif Sharif · Pedaver · October 2026

CONVENTIONAL SUGARCANE Planted in furrows, earthing up needed		PQNK SUGARCANE Planted on permanent beds, no earthing up	
1 Planted in furrows Sets are placed at the bottom of the furrow on compacted soil. 2 Hardpan restricts roots A compacted layer (hardpan) stops deep root growth. Roots spread laterally in the upper soil layer. 3 Earthing up required Soil from the ridges is moved to the base of the plants, usually twice in the first four months. The original furrow becomes a ridge and the ridge becomes a furrow. 4 Shallow anchorage Roots remain relatively shallow, so the tall and heavy crop is prone to lodging, even after earthing up. 5 Crown buried deeply The stool and new tillers become buried under soil, where aeration is poorer. Tillers struggle to emerge. 6 Lower cane left in field At harvest, around 12 inches of the basal cane often remains in the field (PQNK field observation). This lower portion generally has higher sugar content.	 Original ridge Soil from ridge used for earthing up (fills the furrow) Crown buried deeply after earthing up Roots spread laterally in upper soil layer Hardpan (plough pan) restricts deep root growth	1 Planted on permanent beds Sets are placed on the bed surface after breaking the hardpan. 2 No hardpan restriction Hardpan is broken (one-time, 22" subsoiler) before bed formation. Roots can travel deep into the soil profile. 3 No earthing up needed Soil is not repeatedly disturbed. The crown remains near the aerated surface zone. 4 Deep and strong anchorage Roots develop freely and deeply, anchoring the plant naturally and reducing lodging. 5 Healthy tillering Aerated crown favours the emergence and development of new tillers, maintaining a productive multi-generation stool. 6 Full cane length recovered Canes can be cut close to their natural base. The valuable lower portion, with generally higher sugar content, is retained.	 Crown near aerated surface zone Roots go deep into the soil profile
RESULTS IN CONVENTIONAL FIELDS - Lodging common - Fewer tillers and uneven crop - Lower cane left in field (~12 inches) (PQNK observation) - Lower sugar recovery - High labour for earthing up - Higher irrigation water use		RESULTS IN PQNK FIELDS - Strong anchorage - Vigorous and uniform tillers - Full cane length harvested - Higher sugar recovery potential - No earthing up or soil disturbance - Much less irrigation water needed	

PQNK does not begin by asking how to perform a conventional operation more efficiently. It asks why that operation became necessary. When the underlying cause is removed, the operation itself may become unnecessary.

Conventional and PQNK sugarcane compared: furrow planting, hardpan, earthing up and crown burial on the left; one-time hardpan correction, permanent beds and deep rooting on the right.

Abstract

Earthing up is a standard operation in many conventional sugarcane systems: soil is moved toward the cane stool after establishment, often more than once. PQNK approaches the question differently. Rather than asking how to perform earthing up more efficiently, it asks why the operation became necessary. Where cane is planted in a cultivated furrow above a compacted hardpan, roots can be restricted to the loosened upper layer and the developing stool later receives soil from the adjoining ridge for support and field management. PQNK changes this architecture before planting: the hardpan is broken once, permanent raised beds are formed,

cane is established on the protected bed, and subsequent soil disturbance is avoided. This Knowledge Paper explains how deeper unrestricted rooting, an aerated crown, retained roots and selective harvesting can remove much of the need for conventional earthing up.

1. Why the conventional system begins with furrows

After conventional land preparation, sugarcane sets are laid in furrows. At this stage the prepared soil may be dry. Dry soil draws moisture from the planted sets, causing them to lose moisture and dry. When the sets lose too much moisture during this critical establishment period, germination becomes poor and uneven.

The furrow therefore has an important original purpose: it allows irrigation water to be concentrated around the planted sets without wetting the entire prepared field. Farmers can irrigate the furrows frequently with a smaller quantity of water so that the soil immediately surrounding the sets remains wet during germination. In the conventional system, the furrow begins as a practical moisture-management solution for establishing cane in dry, freshly prepared soil.

This explains a sequence that is easily missed. The furrow is first made to maintain moisture around the planted set. Later, as the crop develops, soil from the adjoining ridge is moved back into that same furrow during earthing up. The original furrow is progressively filled and becomes the raised cane row, while the former ridge area becomes the new depression or furrow. PQNK changes this sequence from the beginning by establishing the cane on a permanent, moisture-managed biological bed rather than repeatedly creating and reversing ridges and furrows.

2. Why conventional sugarcane is earthed up

In a conventional ridge-and-furrow system, sugarcane sets are commonly established in the furrow. The cultivated upper layer may be loose, but repeated tillage and machinery traffic can create a compacted hardpan, or plough pan, beneath the normal working depth. In PQNK terminology, hardpan and plough pan are the same compacted layer.

When that compacted layer restricts downward penetration, roots exploit the easier pathways available in the cultivated upper soil and spread laterally. As the crop becomes taller and heavier, a relatively shallow root architecture provides less anchorage than a freely developed deep root system. Lodging can therefore remain a problem even when soil is subsequently placed around the stool.

Earthing up responds to this field architecture. Soil is moved from the adjoining ridges toward the cane row, filling the original furrow and raising soil around the base of the plants. With repeated operations, the original furrow effectively becomes the raised cane row, while the former ridge area becomes the new irrigation or traffic depression. The operation can provide mechanical support, cover exposed roots and help reorganize irrigation pathways.

3. Earthing up treats the consequence, not the hardpan

Adding soil around the cane base can improve support, but it does not remove a compacted layer beneath the root system. The plant may therefore receive more soil around the crown while the principal restriction to deeper rooting remains below.

This distinction is central to the PQNK interpretation. A corrective operation may become normal because it compensates for an earlier condition created by the production system. If the underlying condition is removed before the crop is established, the later corrective operation may no longer be necessary.

4. PQNK changes the field before the cane is planted

PQNK does not begin with the conventional furrow and then try to improve the earthing-up operation. During conversion, the compacted hardpan is broken in a one-time deep operation,

with the current PQNK standard setting the subsoiler at approximately 22 inches. Permanent raised beds are then formed, and machinery traffic is confined to the furrows.

Sugarcane sets are placed on the permanent biological bed. Once established, the production bed is not repeatedly tilled or rebuilt. Roots are therefore given the opportunity to move downward through the soil profile rather than being repeatedly confined to a shallow cultivated layer.

Deep rooting has three simultaneous functions. It increases the volume of soil explored for moisture, expands access to nutrients and biological associations, and creates a larger anchoring system for the tall cane above ground. PQNK therefore seeks to let the plant support itself biologically from below rather than relying on repeated movement of soil around a shallow stool.

5. The crown remains close to the aerated biological surface

Repeated earthing up progressively raises soil around the stool (the clump of shoots that grows from one planting and regrows after each harvest). In heavily earthed-up cane, the basal crown and developing buds can become deeply buried. New tillers then have a longer path to the surface and may encounter a less aerated environment than buds emerging close to the biologically active surface.

PQNK avoids repeatedly burying the crown. The stool remains close to the mulched, aerated surface zone of the permanent bed. This supports the continuing emergence of tillers and is particularly important in the PQNK circular sugarcane concept, where different generations of cane can coexist within the same undisturbed stool.

This should not be interpreted as a claim that earthing up is the only factor controlling tillering. Variety, temperature, light, moisture, plant population, nutrition, disease, and harvest management also influence tiller initiation and survival, which is intrinsically provided by the PQNK system. The PQNK point is narrower: unnecessary deep burial of the crown is avoided while the root system is allowed to develop below.

6. Lodging: build anchorage rather than pile soil around the stem

Sugarcane lodging is influenced by several interacting factors, including stalk height and weight, wind, soil moisture, variety, root strength and root distribution. Earthing up can add mechanical support, but it cannot guarantee an upright crop.

PQNK approaches lodging through root architecture. Once the hardpan has been broken and the bed remains undisturbed, roots can occupy a deeper and larger soil volume. The objective is a plant that is anchored by its own root system. This does not mean that PQNK makes lodging physically impossible under severe wind, saturated soil or other extreme conditions. It means that the system removes a major avoidable restriction to deep anchorage.

7. Why the basal cane matters at harvest

Deep burial also changes the practical cutting point. In PQNK field observations, conventional earthing up can leave a substantial basal section of mature cane below the convenient harvest level; in some observed fields this has approached about 12 inches. That figure is a field observation, not a universal measurement for all conventional sugarcane.

The basal mature internodes are valuable because the lower internodes are the oldest part of the stalk and have been storing sucrose the longest. Leaving usable basal cane in the field can therefore sacrifice both cane mass and recoverable sugar. PQNK keeps the natural cane base accessible so that a mature stalk can be cut close to its base while younger shoots and basal tillers are left standing.

This selective harvest is part of the circular production architecture. The objective is not to destroy the stool at each harvest but to remove the mature cane while protecting the root system, crown and younger generations that continue the plantation.

8. One avoided operation changes more than labour

Eliminating routine earthing up removes repeated soil movement and the labour, machinery energy and field disturbance associated with it. More importantly, it preserves the permanent bed as a biological production zone. Roots remain in place, residues can remain as mulch, traffic remains in the furrows, and the soil is not repeatedly reconstructed around the crop.

Water management also changes. PQNK does not require the large water volumes associated with repeatedly inundating a furrowed field. Sugarcane is not a high-water crop. On mature beds where annual rainfall is 400 mm or more, rain, dew, humidity and capillary rise carry the crop; furrow water is a supplementary option, given only when the soil-ball test shows a need, slowly and never higher than half the furrow depth (no more than a 4-inch head), so that moisture moves laterally into the bed while preserving aeration.

9. From corrective agriculture to biological architecture

Earthing up is a useful example of the difference between conventional process improvement and PQNK system redesign. Conventional agronomy can become highly skilled at performing a recurring operation: when to earth up, how much soil to move, which implement to use and how to irrigate afterwards. PQNK moves one step earlier in the causal chain and asks what field condition created the need for that operation.

In sugarcane, the answer includes the relationship among furrow planting, compacted subsurface soil, shallow root distribution, crop anchorage, crown burial and harvest geometry. PQNK therefore redesigns the production environment before the crop is established: break the hardpan once, form permanent beds, keep traffic in the furrows, avoid subsequent tillage, maintain mulch, manage moisture without inundation and allow the root system to occupy the soil profile.

The resulting objective is not simply 'sugarcane without earthing up.' It is a different biological architecture: deeper anchorage, an aerated crown, continuing tiller emergence, retained roots, selective mature-cane harvest and a permanent stool capable of supporting successive generations. Earthing up becomes unnecessary not because an operation has been omitted, but because the system has been redesigned so that the operation's original purpose is largely removed.

10. A field question: does earthing up control tillering?

PQNK practitioners growing sugarcane on permanent beds asked a question that conventional advisers often raise: is earthing up needed to control the number of tillers? The conventional view is that excess tillers stay thin, never reach millable size and waste purchased fertiliser, so the final population should be held to about 40,000 to 45,000 canes per acre, partly through earthing up. The same practitioners counted 12 to 20 tillers per stool at about 70 days on their PQNK plot, against 4 to 5 on a conventional plot of the same age, and more than 40 tillers on one semi-PQNK stool the previous season.

In PQNK, conventional earthing up is not possible in the first place. The cane is planted in the centre of the permanent 42-inch bed, with the irrigation furrows on either side. There is no ridge to pull soil from, and moving soil onto the cane would destroy the protected bed. Anchorage has to come from the roots below, not from soil piled around the stem.

Nor does PQNK bury the stool to suppress tillers. It lets the plant express its tillering capacity and then manages it. Within the first few weeks after emergence, once several other tillers have enough leaf area to sustain photosynthesis, the dominant leader tiller is removed. The remaining tillers then tend to grow together, far more uniform in height and girth, instead of one dominant cane surrounded by weaker followers. This early leader removal is a different operation from the later selective harvesting of mature canes in circular production.

A high tiller count is therefore not automatically “excess tillering”. It reflects a crown close to the aerated surface, a broken hardpan, deep roots, an undisturbed bed and moisture managed without inundation. But tillers initiated are not the same as millable canes harvested. PQNK does not borrow the conventional population target. Where circular harvesting is not possible and the whole crop is cut at once, the population is shaped through planting density and early leader removal. PQNK rests on natural principles: how many tillers become millable canes depends on the variety’s genetic potential, on how far the soil has progressed from the regenerative to the sustained state, and on planting accuracy.

The Broader PQNK Principle: PQNK does not begin by asking how to perform a conventional operation more efficiently. It asks why that operation became necessary. When the underlying cause is removed, the operation itself may become unnecessary.

Field-Observation Note

Statements concerning approximately 12 inches of basal cane remaining below the practical cutting level, the appearance and uniformity of tillers, and the performance of the PQNK circular sugarcane system are presented as PQNK field observations. They should not be read as universal numerical outcomes for every variety, soil or climate. The causal framework in this paper should be documented further through comparative root excavation, rooting-depth measurements, lodging incidence, tiller survival, harvest height and recoverable-sugar measurements.

Related PQNK Sources

1. PQNK Book, Chapter 37: Sugarcane, The Bamboo Principle. <https://pedaver.com/books/natural-ecosystem-science/sugarcane/>
2. PQNK Book, Chapter 25: Hardpan, and Chapter 23: The Eight-Step Transition Protocol (one-time hardpan correction, permanent raised beds, no subsequent soil disturbance, permanent organic cover, Soil Moisture Management). <https://pedaver.com/books/natural-ecosystem-science/>
3. Pedaver Knowledge Papers KP-027 Sugarcane: The Bamboo Principle and KP-028 Sugarcane Cultivation on PQNK. <https://pedaver.com/papers/>

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